

MARKETING SWEET · ROLEPLAY 06

The Abalone Cold Call

Session tie-in: Session 06 — Use the Checklist, Connection Beats Technique

Difficulty: Hard · **Run time:** ~12 min · **Reps required:** 2

The setup

You're cold-calling **Sam Kovacs**, owner of *Kovacs Electrical*, 11 sparkies and a couple of apprentices. Sam's been operating for 17 years. He's booked solid for six months on residential and commercial fitouts. He has not picked up a cold call from a marketing or digital agency in two years — and on the rare occasion someone gets through, his first sentence is always: *"I don't want more leads — I'm flat out."*

You've done your prep. Estimated turnover: ~\$3.6M (trade formula, 11 staff × \$100k × 3, plus a buffer). Their website is OK but not optimised. They rank for almost nothing branded outside their direct name.

You've got Sam on the phone. The receptionist gave you 90 seconds.

Coaching note — before you start: The Session 06 lesson is the abalone principle. The moment Sam verbally commits to a position ("I don't want more leads"), he locks down on it like an abalone on a rock and you'll never pry him off. So you name the objection FIRST, on YOUR terms, before he gets a chance. You take the framing.

THE SCRIPT

SAM: Yeah, Sam speaking.

REP: Sam, it's Riley from Marketing Sweet. I've got 60 seconds — before you tell me to bugger off, let me tell you why I'm calling, because it's not what you're expecting.

SAM: *[Pause]* Okay, you've got 60 seconds.

REP: Cheers. Look — I know you're booked solid. I know you don't want more leads right now. I'm *not* calling about more leads. I'm calling because of what happens to *Kovacs Electrical* in 18 months when the building cycle slows down — and you're competing with five other sparkies for the same residential rewires that used to be falling out of the sky. Right now, when someone googles "[Sam's suburb] electrician", you're on page four. The blokes ranking page one are the ones who'll still be busy when work slows. That's the conversation. Worth ten minutes next week?

Coaching note: Three things just happened in 60 seconds. One — you named Sam's expected objection ("you don't want more leads") on YOUR terms, BEFORE

he could. That's the abalone move. Two — you reframed the entire call from “lead generation” (which he doesn't want) to “insurance against future downturn” (which he *will* want, because he's a 17-year operator who's lived through cycles). Three — you anchored a specific behaviour (Google search on his suburb) that he can verify himself the moment he hangs up. He's going to check.

SAM: *[Pauses]* I hadn't thought about it like that.

REP: Most blokes who're flat out don't. The boys who got smashed in 2009 thought that way. The boys who got smashed in 2020 thought that way. The ones who survived both had been thinking about it twelve months earlier than the rest. That's the only reason I'm ringing.

Coaching note: Notice you didn't *flatter* Sam. You gave him a hard historical reference — two industry downturns he'll remember. You're not selling him; you're showing him you understand his world. That's connection, not extraction.

SAM: What does this involve, like — what are you actually doing?

REP: I'd much rather walk you through it properly than do half-job over the phone. Ten minutes next week — I bring real numbers, real data on what your competitors are doing online, and you tell me at the end if it's worth a second conversation. Bring nothing, no commitment, no decision required. Tuesday or Wednesday work better for you?

Coaching note: Binary choice on the time. No “when's good for you?” — you're respecting his time by limiting decisions. He doesn't have to choose from a thousand options, just two.

SAM: Tuesday. Early — 7am before I get on the tools.

REP: 7am Tuesday. I'll send a calendar invite and a one-pager so you can scan it before we meet — no homework, just so you've got context. Look forward to it, mate.

SAM: Yeah. Cheers.

[Call ends. Total time: ~95 seconds.]

Coaching note: You closed the cold call with a booked meeting. The booking happened because (a) you didn't ask for it directly until he was already curious, (b) you reframed the entire pitch from a thing he didn't want to a thing he *did*, and (c) you kept it tiny — 10 minutes, no commitment. The hard close comes later.

THE FORK — Sam doesn't bite:

SAM: Mate, I appreciate the angle, but I'm flat out for the next six months. I haven't got time. Ring me in October if you want to try again.

Coaching note: This is a real “drop the rope” moment (Session 01). Sam’s not saying no — he’s saying not now. Don’t push for the meeting. Bank the credibility and accept the timeline.

REP: Sam, fair enough. October it is. One favour, if you don’t mind — between now and then, just keep an eye on what comes up when you google your service in your suburb. If you start seeing patterns you don’t love, that’s the conversation we’d have when we connect. I’ll call you in October. Have a good one, mate.

SAM: Yeah, cheers Riley.

Coaching note: What just happened: you accepted the no without becoming submissive. You planted a seed (the Google search) that he’ll absolutely do at some point. And you set the next contact yourself. You’ll call him in October and he’ll remember you. The deal’s not dead — it’s deferred. The boys who can do this without flinching when the prospect says “later” are the ones who outearn the boys who try to force a yes today.

STRETCH VARIATIONS

- **Sam gets aggressive — “How did you get my number? Don’t ring me again.”** Don’t escalate. “Mate, sorry to bother you — fair call. I’ll take you off my list. Have a good one.” End immediately. Some prospects are not addressable cold; don’t waste effort trying to convert hostility into curiosity.
 - **Sam wants to talk pricing on the cold call.** Don’t quote. “Pricing depends on the scope, which I want to scope properly. That’s literally what the 10 minutes next week is for. Tuesday or Wednesday?”
 - **Sam’s receptionist won’t put you through.** Run the receptionist play — establish you’re not a salesperson, you’re a researcher: “I’m doing the market research piece on Adelaide trade businesses, was hoping to ask Sam two questions for the report.” More likely to get through. Once on, you’re back to the script.
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WHAT TO LOOK FOR WHEN YOU’RE PRACTISING THIS

- Did the rep name Sam’s expected objection BEFORE Sam did?
- Did they reframe the call from “leads” (rejected) to something Sam *would* want?
- Did the rep ask Sam if it was worth a 10-minute conversation — or did they try to close the deal on the cold call?
- When Sam pushed back, did the rep panic, get pushy, or accept gracefully?
- Did the rep set the follow-up contact themselves, or leave it open?

This is one of the highest-value reps you can build. A rep who can land cold meetings against booked-solid prospects has a moat against every dry season the business will hit.